

PC Mag, February 2005

Groping In The Shadows

FOR MOST TECH readers across the world, John C. Dvorak is the most respected columnist. Want proof? Here is a column he wrote for pcmag.com in February.

Last Tuesday's massacre, when Microsoft released a whole slew of patches, begs more than a few questions. First of all, why can't the company consolidate multiple patches that seemingly do the same thing? And second, isn't it about time that we all got a new free operating system that incorporated all the dozens of patches that have been released? The main reason I ask for this is because when I visit my add/remove programs subsystem, the Microsoft patches clog up the list to an extreme.

Now before I go into exactly how Microsoft can get us all one free clean OS, I have to also mention last Tuesday's



weird new patch called the "Malicious Software Removal Tool." This is the first "tool" that I recall showing up in the Windows Update list. I could be wrong, since there have been so many updates, but most of them seem to be security patches rather than full-blown software tools. The question is whether you should even install this new tool.

The Malicious Software Removal Tool is primarily an antispyware product. People who have used the tool and reported on its functionality, say that it never tells you what spyware it is actually removing. The problem I have with it is the concept that it only removes "malicious" spyware. Does this mean that it leaves all those ad-tracking spyware systems installed? Surely they are not meant to be malicious. And since Microsoft sells advertising a la Google on its search engine, it seems unlikely that they'd want to kill that advertising "feature." This seems to explain, to me at least, why the tool doesn't do any detailed reporting. I'll pass, thank you, and stick with the various commercial products that do give me the details.

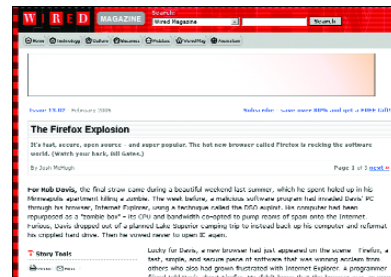
Apparently, the tool is kind of spyware itself, since it reports back to HQ with data on what it has done on your machine. It's not that I care that Microsoft has a huge database of spyware infections and their relative popularity. It's just that I have yet to see what good any of this has done me. They never release the data. So what's the point? The company's argument that it collects this data so it can do a better job doesn't wash with me, given how secretive Microsoft always tends to be. For all I know they are going to push some spyware out there themselves and market it as foolproof.

Want to read more? Visit snipurl.com/digit_dvorak

Wired magazine, February 2005

The Fox Is Lurking

A MONTH AFTER the Firefox browser was released, it already raked up 10 million downloads, making it one of the fastest growing software in the world. *Wired* magazine profiles Firefox, which is a culmination of a collaborative effort of thousands of programmers the world over.



For Rob Davis, the final straw came during a beautiful weekend last summer, which he spent holed up in his Minneapolis apartment killing a zombie. The week before, a malicious software program had invaded Davis' PC through his browser, Internet Explorer, using a technique called the DSO exploit. His computer had been repurposed as a "zombie box"—its CPU and bandwidth co-opted to pump reams of spam onto the Internet. Furious, Davis dropped out of a planned Lake Superior camping trip to instead back up his computer and reformat his crippled hard drive. Then he vowed never to open IE again.

Lucky for Davis, a new browser had just appeared on the scene—Firefox, a fast, simple, and secure piece of software that was winning acclaim from others who also had grown frustrated with Internet Explorer. A programmer friend told Davis about Firefox. He didn't know that the browser was an open source project and a descendant of Netscape Navigator now poised to avenge Netscape's defeat at the hands of Microsoft. He just knew that he didn't want to waste another weekend cursing at his machine. So Davis drove to the friend's house and copied Firefox onto his battered laptop. He hasn't had a problem since—and now he's telling anybody who will listen about Firefox's virtues. "I'm no anti-Microsoft zealot, but it's unconscionable that they make 98 per cent of the operating systems in the world and they let things like this happen to people," says Davis, a PR man by day who liked Firefox so much that he initiated a fundraising campaign to help promote the browser. "There's a lot of pain out there."

Firefox couldn't have arrived at a better time for people like Davis—or at a worse time for Microsoft. Ever since Internet Explorer toppled Netscape in 1998, browser innovation has been more or less limited to pop-up ads, spyware, and viruses. Over the past six years, IE has become a third world bus depot, the gathering point for a crush of hawkers, con artists, and pickpockets. The recent outbreak of malware—from the spyware on Davis' machine to the .ject Trojan, which uses a bug in IE to snatch sensitive data from an infected PC—has prompted early adopters to look for an alternate Web browser. Even in beta, Firefox's clean, intuitive interface, quick page-loading, and ability to elude intruders elicited a thunderous response. In the month following its official November launch, more than 10 million people downloaded Firefox, taking the first noticeable bite out of IE's market share since the browser wars of the mid-'90s.

Excited about reading more on the Firefox revolution? Go to snipurl.com/digit_firefox